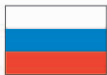


Russian Federation



The Russian Federation was the core of the old Soviet Union, which broke up in 1991. Russia is still the world's largest state. Its diversity is a source of both strength and problems.



GEOGRAPHY

The Ural Mountains divide the European steppes and forests from the tundra and forests of Siberia. South-central deserts and mountains.



CLIMATE

Continental in European Russia. Elsewhere climate ranges from sub-arctic to Mediterranean and hot desert.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Besides the ethnic Russian majority, there are 57 "nationalities" with territorial status, and a further 95 minorities without their own region. Most ethnic republics are in European Russia. The number of Muslims is rising, though the overall population is predicted to fall by 30% in 50 years. Nation-based separatism is brutally suppressed, as in Chechnya. HIV/AIDS is spreading. Healthcare and education are underfunded. Crime is a serious problem.



INSIGHT: *The Trans-Siberian Railroad, which runs 5578 miles (9297 km) from Moscow to Vladivostok, is the longest in the world, passing through eight time zones*

FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Russian Federation

DATE OF FORMATION: 1480

CAPITAL: Moscow

POPULATION: 141 million

TOTAL AREA: 6,592,735 sq. miles
(17,075,200 sq. km)

DENSITY: 21 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Russian*, other

RELIGIONS: Orthodox Christian 75%,
Muslim 14%, other 11%

ETHNIC MIX: Russian 80%, other 13%,
Tatar 4%, Ukrainian 2%, Chavash 1%

GOVERNMENT: Mixed presidential–
parliamentary system

CURRENCY: Russian rouble = 100 kopeks